Chapter 4

Farmers and Farming

Farmers grow the food that we eat every day. Most of the people in India's villages earn their living from farming.

How farmers grow crops

1. Preparing the soil: The farmer ploughs the field to make the soil soft and loose. Some farmers use a plough pulled by bullocks, and others use a tractor.
2. Sowing: The farmer puts seeds into the soil.
3. Watering: Crops need water to grow. Watering the fields with water from canals, wells or tube wells is called irrigation.
4. Adding manure: The farmer adds manure to the soil to make it rich.
5. Weeding: Unwanted plants called weeds grow along with the crop. The farmer pulls them out.
6. Harvesting: When the crop is ready, the farmer cuts it. This is called harvesting.

Main crops of India

- Food crops: rice, wheat, pulses such as dal, and millets such as jowar, bajra and ragi.
- Other crops: sugarcane, cotton, tea, coffee and jute.

Rice needs a lot of water. Wheat needs less water and a cool season to grow.

Crops of different seasons

India has two main farming seasons.

- Kharif crops are sown when the monsoon rains begin, in June and July. They are harvested in September and October. Rice, maize and cotton are kharif crops.
- Rabi crops are sown in winter, from October to December. They are harvested in spring, in March and April. Wheat, mustard and gram are rabi crops.

Many farmers in India depend on the monsoon rains. If the rains are late or there is too little rain, the crops suffer.

From the farm to our plate

After harvesting, the farmer takes the crop to a market called a mandi. Traders buy the crop there and send it to shops in towns and cities. From the shops, the food reaches our homes.

Farmers work very hard in the hot sun and in the rain. We should respect them and never waste food.

Let's think

1. What is irrigation?
2. Name two kharif crops and two rabi crops.
3. How does food reach our homes from the farm?

New words

harvesting - cutting and collecting a crop when it is ready
mandi - a market where farmers sell their crops